The Art of Uncertain Topoplots: Designing and Evaluating Uncertainty Visualizations for EEG/ERP Data

Vladimir Mikheev, Daniel Weiskopf, and Benedikt Ehinger

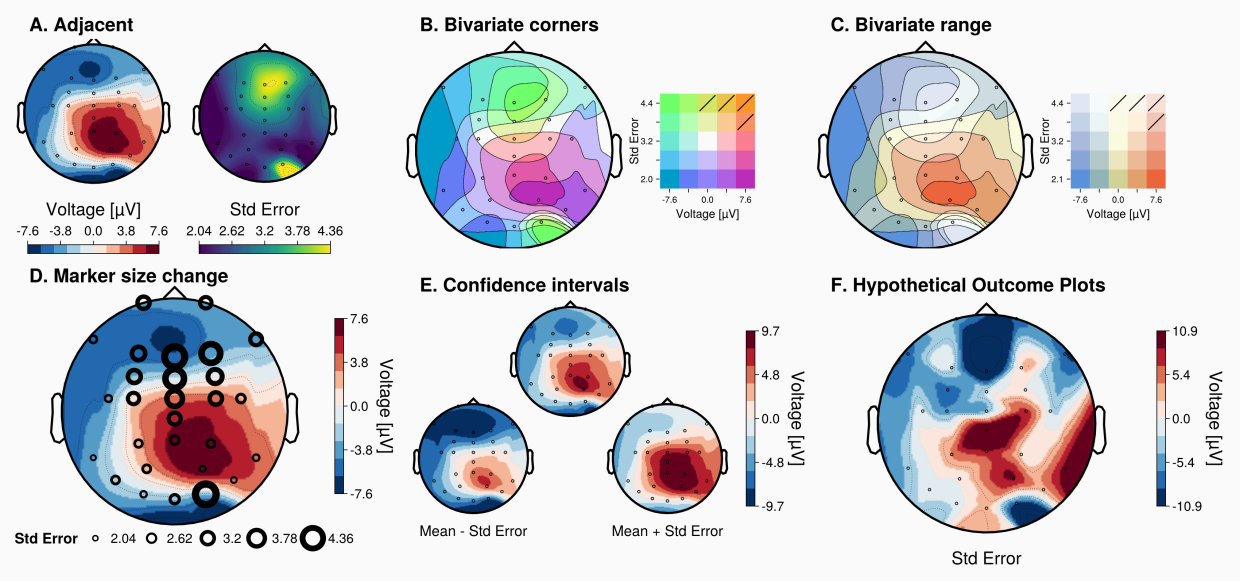


Figure 1: Overview of the evaluated uncertainty-visualization designs.

Abstract—TODO: Abstract

Index terms—Data visualization, Electroencephalography, Human factors, Uncertainty

1 Introduction

Scientific estimates are often accompanied by uncertainty, but representing uncertainty for spatial and multivariate data is challenging task. For individual estimates and curves, familiar techniques such as error bars and confidence bands provide relatively direct ways to communicate uncertainty [43]. But in spatial visualizations the estimated signal and its uncertainty vary across space and need to be shown at the same time.

EEG/ERP topographic plots are a useful case for studying this problem. EEG measures electrical potentials at electrodes distributed across the scalp. ERP or event-related potentials are averaged and time-locked EEG trials. A topographic plot or **topoplot** is a figure with ERP over a two-dimensional representation of the head, often interpolated. Colour usually represents the sign and magnitude of the estimated voltage, allowing researchers to inspect the spatial distribution of signals. Topoplots are also one of the most familiar visualization types in the EEG/ERP community. In our previous survey of 213 M/EEG researchers, 52% of respondents reported having previously created topoplots. This is the second results after conventional ERP waveforms (61%) [31].

- *Vladimir Mikheev is with Computational Cognitive Science, Institute for Visualization and Interactive Systems (VIS), University of Stuttgart, Stuttgart, Germany .*
- *Daniel Weiskopf is with Visualization Research Center (VISUS) and Institute for Visualization and Interactive Systems (VIS), University of Stuttgart, Stuttgart, Germany .*
- *Benedikt Ehinger is with Computational Cognitive Science, Institute for Visualization and Interactive Systems (VIS), Stuttgart Center for Simulation Science (SC SimTech), University of Stuttgart, Stuttgart, Germany .*

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Conventional topoplots generally show the estimated voltage without an accompanying measure of its precision. There is no established visual convention for integrating uncertainty into these maps. Although there are some software solutions for representation of uncertaint in EEG visualization [11].

Showing uncertainty could help researchers distinguish regions with relatively stable estimates from regions with larger variability and provide a visual impression of the local signal-to-noise structure. On the other hand, adding another visual variable to an already familiar spatial representation may hinder the perception of the underlying ERP pattern. This creates a broader visualization question: **how can uncertainty be added to an established spatial visualization while preserving the primary signal that users already know how to read?** This difficulty is reflected by [1]: they reviewed 1,451 figures from six neuroscience journals, finding that uncertainty was particularly underrepresented in visualizations of data with more than three features, with only 20% indicating uncertainty.

Before the quantitative evaluation, we conducted qualitative interviews with nine EEG/ERP experts to understand how topoplots are used in practice, how researchers think about uncertainty, and what they expect from an uncertainty-aware representation. The interviewed researchers valued uncertainty representation on topoplots but reported a lack of clear conventions or guidance for doing so. These findings helped us formulate the research gap, select the visualization approaches, and design the later experimental tasks.

Building on prior uncertainty-visualization work and our qualitative interviews with EEG/ERP experts, we created several uncertainty representations and compared them with the conventional topoplot in a user study. We tested whether showing uncertainty changes participants' ability to recognize the underlying spatial ERP pattern, how well different representations support judgments that require combining

Field	Study	Evidence and sample	Main finding
Neuroscience	Allen et al. (2012) [1]	Publication audit: 288 articles; 1,451 figures	Only about 20% of visualisations with three features represented uncertainty.[1]
Ecosystem science	Yanai et al. (2021) [44]	Publication audit: 132 articles	Studies reported numerical estimates for only 42% of relevant uncertainty sources on average; 54% of studies reported such estimates for fewer than half.
ERP visualization practice	Mikheev et al. (2024) [31]	Practitioner survey: 157 M/EEG practitioners who had published a paper with an ERP plot	Among the 157 respondents who had published an ERP plot, 40% reported not including error bars.
Geospatial / public-health mapping	Jain et al. (2026) [19]	Publication audit: 66 articles containing maps of climate-related infectious diseases in the Asia-Pacific region	Only 3 of 66 studies (4.5%) visually integrated uncertainty into their maps; 26 studies (39%) did not report uncertainty at all.
Visualization software	Petek et al. (2026) [35]	Software comparison: 5 visualization tools: Matplotlib, ggplot2, ggdist, Seaborn, and ggdibbler; 18 example uncertainty visualization	For 13 of 18 visualisations (72%), all five tools lack a wrapper to quantify uncertainty, so users need to construct visual encoding manually.

Table 1: Representative evidence of incomplete uncertainty reporting and visualization across scientific domains and limited software support.

signal and uncertainty, and how participants experience and interpret the different designs. The study combines formative expert interviews, controlled performance evaluation, subjective ratings, and open-ended qualitative explanations of participants' judgments and decisions.

To our knowledge, this is the first systematic study to compare multiple uncertainty-visualization strategies for EEG/ERP topoplots in a controlled user study. While uncertainty has occasionally been represented in EEG visualization, there is no established practice for integrating it into scalp topographies, and the relative effectiveness of alternative representations has not been systematically evaluated.

Our contributions are fourfold. First, we report qualitative insights from EEG/ERP experts on current topoplot practices and the challenges of communicating uncertainty in them. Second, we created a design pool of uncertainty representations for EEG/ERP topoplots. Third, we provide empirical evidence of how different plot types affect participants' ability to interpret the underlying spatial ERP pattern and make judgments that combine signal and uncertainty. This is complemented by participants' subjective ratings and qualitative feedback explaining their preferences and interpretation difficulties. Finally, we derive practical recommendations for the usage of uncertainty-aware EEG/ERP topoplots.

2 Related Work

2.1 Uncertainty Is Often Missing from Scientific Reporting and Visualization

Uncertainty is routinely omitted or incompletely communicated across scientific domains. Boukhelifa and Duke describe a persistent divide between the recognized importance of uncertainty in visualization research and its limited adoption in practice [3]. Similarly, Hullman's survey of visualization authors found that, although authors generally acknowledged the value of communicating uncertainty, direct uncertainty depiction was routinely omitted [16]. Table 1 summarizes this observation with evidence from neuroscience, ecosystem science, geospatial mapping, and visualization software.

Limited software support is one practical reason why uncertainty visualizations may remain uncommon. Although many uncertainty visualization techniques have been proposed, they are not necessarily available as standard functionality in commonly used visualization systems. Petek et al. compared five visualization tools across 18 example uncertainty visualizations: for 13 of these examples, all five tools required users to quantify uncertainty themselves and implement its visual encoding through custom plotting code, rather than relying on dedicated uncertainty-visualization functionality (their Table 3) [35].

This software gap has been reported across multiple visualization ecosystems and application domains. Kay notes that support for uncertainty visualization in existing Grammar-of-Graphics implementations remains largely limited to conventional representations such as error bars, uncertainty bands, and density plots, while many techniques proposed in visualization research remain difficult to construct [22]. In geospatial visualization, Koo et al. identify a lack of uncertainty-visualization tools in standard GIS environments and implement dedicated uncertainty encodings as an ArcGIS extension [24]. Earlier work in GIS likewise observed that, despite a broad conceptual literature on uncertainty visualization, implemented tools and pilot projects remained rare [25]. In medical visualization, Gillmann et al. further reported that, to their knowledge, no commercially available uncertainty-aware visualization technique was available in medical workstations [13].

2.2 Visual Encodings for Spatial Uncertainty

Kinkeldey et al. [23] classify spatial uncertainty visualizations along three dimensions: *intrinsic* versus *extrinsic* (modifying existing visual properties or adding graphical elements), *coincident* versus *adjacent* (showing data and uncertainty together or separately), and *static* versus *dynamic* representations. We focus on five approaches used in our study.

Markers and *glyphs* represent uncertainty through graphical elements added to a spatial display. Their visual properties, such as size, colour, or opacity, can encode uncertainty independently of the underlying data [4, 28].

Bivariate colour maps encode two quantities within a single spatial view using a two-dimensional colour legend [40, 42]. MacEachren [28] proposed using this approach to display data values together with their uncertainty, assigning different colour properties to each quantity. The approach was popularized by the U.S. Census Bureau's bivariate choropleth maps of 1970 Census data, described by Meyer et al. in 1975 [30]. Subsequent evaluations found that untrained readers had considerable difficulty interpreting such maps [28, 32], and Wainer and Francolini reported a threefold elementary map-reading error rate relative to paired univariate maps (.24 versus .08) [42]. Later work developed task-based quality criteria for static 2D colormaps [2], although that assessment explicitly excluded colormaps designed for bivariate metric encoding.

[1] In Allen et al.'s terminology, three-dimensional graphics represent three data variables, which can be shown in a flat figure using two axes and colour; the term does not necessarily imply a 3D spatial rendering [1].

Paper	Field	Data	Visualizations compared	Type	Sample size	How it was measured
Wainer & Francolini [42]	Geospatial mapping	R	Univariate and bivariate colour maps	PT	N: 16	Elementary map-reading error rate; response time
Sanyal et al. [36]	General	S	Error bars, glyph size, glyph colour, surface colour	PT	N: 27	Search and counting accuracy; response time
MacEachren et al. [29]	Geospatial mapping	S	Size, colour, transparency vs. recognizable pictorial symbols	PT, SR	E1: 72; E2: 30; pilot: 31	Intuitiveness judgments; comparison accuracy; response time
Correll & Gleicher [5]	General	S	Error bars, box plots, gradients, violin plots	PJ	E1: 96; E2: 48; E3: 96	Prediction accuracy; likelihood judgments; judgment confidence
Scholz & Lu [37]	Geospatial mapping	R	Fuzziness, lightness, transparency, shape	DM, SR	N: 60	Decision choices; preference ratings and rankings
Greis et al. [14]	Weather forecasting	M	Textual estimates, SD and quantiles; line/area charts, boxplots, bar charts, shaded bars, PDF/CDF plots	DM, SR	Survey: 90; game: 44 (38 rated)	Subjective ratings; farming-game decision choices
Hullman et al. [18]	Chemical concentrations	S	HOPs, error bars, violin plots	PJ	N: 288	Probability-estimation error; total completion time
Gschwandtner et al. [15]	Event time intervals	S	Gradients, violin plots, probability plots, error bars, ambiguation	PT, PJ	N: 72	Accuracy; estimation error; response time
Correll et al. [6]	Spatial mapping	S	Adjacent maps, bivariate maps, VSUPs	PT, DM	E1: 24; E2: 24	Identification accuracy; response time; decision choices
Fernandes et al. [10]	Public transport	S	Dotplots, CDFs, PDFs, intervals, text, baseline	DM	N: 408	Expected reward relative to optimal; variability across trials
Kale et al. [20]	Employment trends	S	HOPs, error bars, line ensembles	PT	E1: 50; E2: 150	Trend-identification accuracy; perceptual sensitivity (JND); judgment confidence
Kusumastuti et al. [26]	General	S	Ensemble, summary, distribution displays	DM	E1: 118; E2: 56	Decision accuracy; response time
Sterzik et al. [39]	Biomolecular structures	M	Colour, clouds, ensembles, hulls, sausages, contours, texture, waves, noise	PT, QF	Total: 1,756; experts: 6	Mapping-direction judgments; uncertainty-estimation accuracy; qualitative expert feedback

Table 2: Empirical evaluations of uncertainty visualization techniques.
Data: S = synthetic or simulated data; R = real observational data; M = mixed real and simulated data;
Task type: PT = perceptual tasks; PJ = probability judgments; DM = decision-making tasks; SR = subjective ratings; QF = qualitative feedback.
N = number of participants; E1–E3 = separate experiments.

Adjacent or *juxtaposed maps* display an estimate and its uncertainty in separate, spatially aligned views [4]. Each quantity can use its own colour scale, allowing viewers to compare the two maps.

Interval-based representations display an estimate together with its lower and upper bounds. For spatial data, these bounds can be shown as separate maps alongside the estimate [11]. Depending on the statistical method, the bounds may represent confidence intervals or 1 +- standard error.

Hypothetical outcome plots use animation to display samples from a modelled distribution [18]. For spatial data, each frame shows a possible spatial pattern, communicating uncertainty through variation across successive frames.

2.3 Evaluating Uncertainty Visualizations

Previous studies have evaluated uncertainty visualizations using perceptual tasks, probability judgments, decision-making tasks, and subjective assessments. Table 2 summarizes representative empirical studies, distinguishing what researchers assessed from how they measured it.

Perceptual studies assess how accurately and quickly participants identify areas with high uncertainty or compare its magnitude across different areas, typically measuring accuracy and response time [18]. Both approaches provide objective measures, but they test different abilities: reading uncertainty is not the same as using it to make a decision.

Decision-making studies go beyond interpretation accuracy. Correll et al. [6] examined whether uncertainty affected participants' choices, whereas Fernandes et al. [10] measured decision quality through expected payoffs. This distinction matters because a visualization can change how cautiously people behave without necessarily improving their decisions. *Subjective assessments* address another question: whether a visualization is understandable, useful, or preferred. Studies combining ratings with behavioral tasks, such as Greis et al. [14], allow these outcomes to be examined separately.

No single evaluation measure captures all aspects of uncertainty visualization effectiveness. Reviews by Kinkeldey et al. [23] and Hullman et al. [17] emphasize the importance of task selection and distinguishing perceptual performance from decision quality. Accordingly, our study combines two tasks: pattern comparison, assessing whether users can recognize EEG scalp patterns, and signal-to-noise integration, assessing whether they can use voltage and standard error together. Subjective ratings and qualitative feedback complement these performance measures by examining participants' experiences with each visualization design.

2.4 Uncertainty in EEG/ERP Visualization

In ERP waveforms, uncertainty is commonly shown using error bars or shaded confidence intervals [1, 21, 34]. EEG scalp maps can also display statistical results, such as test statistics or significance markers, but these do not directly show uncertainty in the estimated voltage [34].

Some EEG tools already provide ways to visualize uncertainty. LIMO EEG calculates bootstrap confidence intervals for individual electrodes and time points, but its published examples show statistical scalp maps and confidence intervals on selected waveforms separately [34]. The R package `diegr` offers a more direct approach: its `plot_topo_mean()` function displays three scalp maps showing the lower confidence bound, mean, and upper confidence bound [11].

Although these approaches exist, it remains unclear which uncertainty visualizations work best for EEG/ERP topoplots. Neither publication systematically evaluates how users interpret different visualization designs. Our study addresses this gap by comparing ways to display uncertainty alongside estimated scalp voltage, rather than uncertainty in interpolation or source localization.

2.5 Research Gap

The literature provides established uncertainty-visualization techniques and individual EEG implementations, but little comparative evidence for EEG/ERP topoplots. To our knowledge, the alternative strategies

have not been systematically compared in a controlled user study in this context, and no established visual convention guides their use. The open question is which representations preserve the underlying spatial signal while supporting uncertainty-aware judgments. Addressing this question requires evidence about performance as well as participants' explanations of why they prefer particular representations or struggle to interpret them.

3 Formative Qualitative Study

At the beginning we conducted a formative qualitative study to understand how EEG/ERP researchers currently use topoplots, how they conceptualize uncertainty, and which barriers they encounter when communicating it in spatial EEG representations. The interviews also served to identify relevant user tasks and requirements for the subsequent visualization design and quantitative study.

3.1 Participants

We conducted semi-structured interviews with nine participants with experience in EEG/ERP research or clinical EEG. The sample covered different application contexts, including fundamental neuroscience, brain-computer interface research, and clinical EEG practice.

3.2 Interview Guide

We used a semi-structured interview guide consisting of 14 main questions; the complete guide is provided in the supplementary material. A shortened version containing the main questions was provided to participants, while the interviewer used an extended version containing optional probes.

The interview covered six main topics: participants' EEG/ERP background and visualization practices; their understanding and current use of uncertainty; the purposes and audiences for which they use topoplots; current and potential approaches to showing uncertainty on topoplots; perceived value and barriers to uncertainty visualization; and requirements for future topoplot tools.

Questions were deliberately open-ended, and the order and depth of follow-up questions could vary depending on the participant's responses. The interviewer maintained a neutral stance and did not suggest that uncertainty should or should not be visualized.

3.3 Procedure and Transcription

The interviews lasted approximately 15–30 minutes and were audio-recorded. The full interview guide is provided in Table S1 of the supplementary material. At the beginning of each interview, participants explicitly consented to the recording, to public sharing of an anonymized transcript for research purposes, and to the use of anonymized quotations in publications.

Audio recordings were transcribed using Voice AI, the speech-to-text service provided through the Academic Cloud/GWDG [12]. Transcripts were anonymized before analysis and publication.

3.4 Analysis and Implications for the Visualization Design

The interviews were analyzed using a structured qualitative content-analysis approach. Responses were first organized according to the interview questions and then compared across participants to identify recurring practices, concerns, and requirements.

Participants saw value in communicating uncertainty, but rarely visualized spread-related uncertainty directly on topoplots. They reported ambiguity about how to represent it, limited support in the software they used, and a lack of clear conventions or guidance. Together with the individual implementations described in the related work, these findings motivate evaluating alternative representations and developing practical guidance for communicating uncertainty spatially.

Participants' accounts referred both to variability or precision, such as standard deviation or standard error, and to statistical evidence or signal reliability, such as signal-to-noise ratios, test statistics, or significance values. These quantities answer different questions: significance does not directly describe the precision of a voltage estimate. We focused the subsequent study on representing standard error alongside estimated voltage.

Several recurring uses of topoplots were identified, including recognizing expected spatial ERP patterns, comparing experimental conditions, assessing plausible spatial distributions, and locating relevant signals. We used these common practices as the basis for constructing the tasks in the quantitative study.

Participants also proposed possible uncertainty representations. For example, R2 suggested showing three topoplots representing an uncertainty interval together with the estimate. This suggestion helped motivate the inclusion of an interval-based representation with precedent in EEG visualization. We combined these interview-derived requirements with existing visualization approaches to construct the design pool evaluated in the subsequent study.

4 Design Space of Uncertainty Visualizations

We selected six approaches for representing standard error alongside estimated voltage by combining designs from prior visualization work with ideas from the formative interviews. The two bivariate topoplot designs were inspired by the range and corners models described by Strode et al. and by Correll et al.'s Value-Suppressing Uncertainty Palettes [6, 40]. The resulting bivariate topoplots are our original designs: we used these color-model concepts as starting points and adapted them to spatially continuous EEG/ERP topoplots that jointly encode signed voltage and standard error. Adjacent plots, uncertainty markers, and hypothetical outcome animation were also informed by existing visualization approaches and adapted for our study. The interval-based representation was suggested by participant R2 and has precedent in the three-map display provided by `diegr` [11]. We included a conventional topoplot without uncertainty information as a baseline.

The designs differ in whether uncertainty is presented in separate maps, integrated into color, overlaid as markers, or conveyed through animation. This selection allowed us to examine how these approaches support two needs identified in the interviews: preserving recognizable spatial patterns and supporting judgments that combine the estimated signal and its uncertainty.

We aimed to use RdBu or similar diverging red–blue color schemes for voltage wherever possible, to maintain visual consistency across designs. We used discrete (binned) colormaps, motivated by Padilla et al.'s study of grayscale 2D scalar fields [33], which found improved accuracy for value lookup and highest-point identification under some binning conditions, while continuous encodings were often faster. For univariate voltage maps, we quantized RdBu into 10 colors. Both bivariate designs used a 5×5 grid, with five bins each for voltage and standard error, yielding 25 color combinations.

4.1 Basic topoplot

The basic topoplot served as the baseline condition. It displays only the estimated EEG/ERP voltage amplitude using a diverging color scale, such that color encodes both the sign and magnitude of the signal. No information about standard error (SE) is shown.

4.2 Adjacent plots

The adjacent-plots design was inspired by the EEGVIS toolbox [8]. It presents the estimated signal and its SE in two separate topoplots. The signal map uses a diverging color scale to represent negative and positive voltage amplitudes, whereas the SE map uses a sequential color scale because SE is non-negative. This design preserves a familiar univariate encoding for each quantity, but requires viewers to compare corresponding spatial regions across the two maps.

4.3 Bivariate color: corners

The corner encoding adapts the corners model described by Strode et al. [40], using the TeulingFig3 four-corner, two-dimensional color legend [41] to jointly represent signal and SE.

The corners model is intended for analyses that emphasize extreme combinations of two variables while de-emphasizing intermediate

values [40]. This makes it suitable for our study tasks, in which viewers must locate and compare regions combining strongly positive or negative voltage with low or high uncertainty.

We selected this palette because it received the highest assessment category for elementary localization and identification (ER1), equal visual importance (ER2), and elementary comparison (ER3) on dark backgrounds in Bernard et al.'s task-based evaluation [2]. Its corners use distinct hues so that the four joint extrema can be identified and compared. We further adjusted the palette to improve separation between neighboring combinations, following the broader warning that blue–violet mixtures in bivariate maps can be difficult to distinguish [40]. Hatched legend cells mark combinations absent from the displayed topoplot.

4.4 Bivariate color: range

The range encoding adapts the range model described by Strode et al. [40] while retaining the familiar cool-to-warm diverging organization of conventional EEG/ERP topoplots.

The range model is intended for analyses in which viewers examine the range of one variable within levels or categories of another [40]. In our application, it supports assessing how SE varies within regions of positive or negative voltage while preserving the spatial signal pattern needed for comparison.

Voltage is represented along a diverging color dimension, with cool and warm hues indicating opposite polarities. SE is encoded along the second dimension by progressively increasing lightness and decreasing chroma while approximately preserving the hue associated with each voltage level. Consequently, regions with greater uncertainty appear lighter and less saturated, while the underlying color identity of the voltage remains recognizable. As in the corners design, hatched legend cells indicate color combinations absent from the displayed topoplot.

4.5 Interval-based representation

The interval-based condition uses three adjacent maps showing the estimated mean, the mean minus one SE, and the mean plus one SE. In our implementation, the bounds indicate $\pm$ one SE rather than a 95% confidence interval. Viewers compare the spatial voltage distribution across the three maps: larger differences indicate greater SE, while smaller differences indicate more precise estimates.

This visualization has precedents in both EEG and fMRI. For EEG, the R package `diegr` provides a `plot_topo_mean()` function that uses adjacent topographic maps of the mean and its lower and upper confidence bounds [11]. For fMRI, Engel and Burton proposed an analogous three-map representation showing an estimated activation map together with its lower and upper confidence bounds [9].

4.6 Uncertainty markers

The uncertainty-marker design overlays spatial markers on the voltage topoplot and maps SE to marker size. Larger markers indicate higher SE and smaller markers indicate lower SE. This separates the visual channels used for the two quantities: color represents the estimated signal, while size represents uncertainty.

Marker size is an established visual channel for quantitative uncertainty [4, 28]. We included this condition to examine how an added size encoding affects reading of the underlying voltage pattern and its uncertainty.

4.7 Hypothetical outcome animation

This condition adapts the hypothetical-outcome approach of Hullman et al. to spatial EEG/ERP data [18]. We generated a finite sequence of plausible topoplots from the estimated signal and its SE and displayed them as an animation with a stable visual mapping across frames. Each frame depicts one hypothetical outcome, not a successive point in time. Regions that remain visually similar across frames are comparatively stable, whereas regions that vary strongly indicate greater uncertainty.

5 Quantitative User Study

5.1 Research Questions

The quantitative study addressed three research questions:

RQ1. Pattern comparison: To what extent do uncertainty visualizations preserve the ability to recognize the underlying spatial pattern in an EEG/ERP topoplot?

RQ2. Uncertainty integration: How well can users integrate the estimated signal and its uncertainty to identify spatial regions with a high signal-to-noise ratio, and how does performance depend on the visualization technique?

RQ3. Subjective evaluation: How do users subjectively evaluate the different approaches to visualizing uncertainty in EEG/ERP topoplots?

5.2 Participants

We recruited participants with experience in EEG/ERP research or analysis. The study targeted researchers and students familiar with EEG/ERP data and topographic visualizations. Participation was voluntary.

A total of 114 participants were included in the quantitative analysis. Country-of-work percentages were calculated from 110 valid responses: two participants selected "Prefer not to say," and two entered occupations rather than countries. *TODO: Add remaining demographics, EEG experience, and exclusion criteria.*

5.3 Stimuli

We used three characteristic ERP topographic patterns: mismatch negativity (MMN), P3, and N170 [21]. For each pattern, we prepared a pool of ten pattern variations, from which individual stimuli were selected during the experiment.

The patterns were displayed using seven visualization conditions: a basic topoplot and six uncertainty visualizations selected from the design pool described above. Each visualization technique was combined with each of the three ERP patterns, forming a 7×3 within-participant design.

All visualization types were implemented in Julia using Makie [7]. We used this implementation to render the static plots and hypothetical-outcome animations presented as stimuli in the online survey.

5.4 Tasks

5.4.1 Task 1: Pattern comparison

Task 1 tested whether adding uncertainty information interfered with recognition of the underlying spatial pattern. In each trial, participants saw a target ERP pattern and two alternative topoplots and selected the alternative that matched the target most closely. One alternative belonged to the same ERP-pattern class as the target, whereas the other was drawn from one of the two remaining classes.

Each visualization technique was shown once with MMN, P3, and N170, resulting in 21 trials. Each trial was shown on a separate page, and trial order was randomized for each participant. For each trial, the correct and distractor pattern variations were sampled from their respective stimulus pools. The distractor class was randomly selected from the two non-target classes. The position of the correct response alternated between the first and second alternative across the predefined trials.

5.4.2 Task 2: Uncertainty integration

Task 2 tested whether participants could combine information about the estimated voltage and its uncertainty to identify a relevant spatial region. On each trial, participants saw one topographic visualization and were asked to select the region with the highest signal-to-noise ratio (SNR), defined in the study as

$$\mathrm{SNR} = \left| \frac{\text{Voltage}}{\text{Standard Error}} \right|. \tag{1}$$

Responses were collected using a separate 64-region selectable scalp layout displayed next to the stimulus. We constructed this layout as a fixed SVG representation of the scalp divided into 64 individually selectable polygonal regions, labelled internally from R01 to R64. The polygon layer was aligned with a scalp-montage reference, and the

same spatial layout was used for every trial. Participants selected one region by clicking directly on the corresponding polygon.

As in Task 1, the complete design contained each combination of the seven visualization techniques and three ERP patterns, giving 21 trials, each presented on a separate page. For each ERP pattern, seven distinct variations were randomly selected from its pool and assigned across the seven visualization techniques. Trial order was randomized for each participant.

5.4.3 Task 3: Subjective evaluation

After completing the objective tasks, participants evaluated each of the seven visualization techniques subjectively. Four aspects were assessed on 5-point Likert scales: how helpful the visualization was for comparing spatial patterns, how helpful it was for detecting relevant spatial regions, how helpful it was for representing signal and uncertainty, and how visually appealing it was.

5.5 Procedure

The study was conducted online. Before beginning the study, participants were informed about data anonymisation, public data sharing, voluntary participation, and their right to withdraw, and provided informed consent. Participants then answered background questions concerning their experience with EEG/ERP analysis.

Participants then received an explanation of the visualization techniques and completed Task 1 (pattern comparison), followed by brief feedback questions. They next received instructions for Task 2 (uncertainty integration) and completed its randomized trials. Finally, participants completed Task 3 (subjective evaluation).

5.6 Measures

[TODO: Measures]

5.7 Statistical Analysis

[TODO: Statistical analysis]

6 Results

6.1 Task Performance

[TODO: Task-performance results]

6.2 Subjective Evaluation

[TODO: Subjective-evaluation results]

6.3 Qualitative Feedback

[TODO: Qualitative-feedback results]

7 Discussion

Following Lam et al.'s evaluation framework [27], our study combines understanding of environments and work practices (UWP) through formative expert interviews with controlled evaluation of user performance (UP) and user experience (UE) in the subsequent quantitative study.

Our study design was informed by several pitfalls identified in design study methodology [38]. We aimed to avoid *premature advance* and *premature design commitment* (PF-1, PF-20) by conducting formative interviews with EEG/ERP researchers before finalizing the visualization designs and quantitative tasks, grounding the study in domain practices. We also retained the conventional topoplot as a baseline and preserved familiar aspects of its encoding in several conditions, reflecting the recommendation not to ignore existing practices that already work well (PF-15). Finally, we did not treat subjective preference as sufficient evidence of effectiveness: objective task performance was combined with subjective ratings and open-ended feedback, addressing the concern captured by PF-26. At the same time, the controlled quantitative tasks do not reproduce the full complexity of real EEG/ERP analysis workflows, so the study should not be interpreted as a full real-world case study, consistent with the caution expressed in PF-25.

[TODO: Discussion]

8 Limitations

[TODO: Limitations]

9 Conclusion

[TODO: Conclusion]

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